

Postpartum - Headache - Female (Adult)

Algorithm 1425 | Adult (18 years and older) | Gender at birth: Female

Definition

- Postpartum headache assessment for a person who has given birth within the last year. Pre-eclampsia is especially relevant in the first days or weeks after birth; other pregnancy-related complications can occur later.
- Adult patient.
- Female.

Initial assessment

1. [DURATION] How many days/weeks since delivery?
2. [PAIN_SCALE] How severe is the headache, 0-10?
3. [YES_NO] Any vision changes, swelling, or pain below the ribs?
4. [YES_NO] If the patient is under 18, can they speak privately now, and do they say they feel safe with the accompanying adult?

Triage and redirect questions

1. Redirect → Headache

Is this a non-postpartum headache presentation without recent childbirth?

A headache not occurring in the postpartum period belongs in the Headache pathway.

1. Disposition level 100

Is there a severe headache that doesn't go away with simple painkillers, vision problems (blurred vision or flashing lights), pain below the ribs, sudden swelling of the face/hands/feet, feeling very unwell, persistent heartburn unresponsive to medication, or vomiting?

NHS.UK guidance lists these as pre-eclampsia warning signs that can appear in the days or weeks after birth and always need immediate evaluation.

1. Disposition level 70

Is there a new or persistent postpartum headache without the emergency features above?

A new or persistent headache after birth requires clinical assessment because remote questioning alone cannot exclude a hypertensive, neurological, anaesthetic-related, or infectious cause.

Advice

Emergency postpartum pre-eclampsia precautions

- Call Qatar emergency services on 999 now. Do not drive yourself. Tell the call handler that the patient gave birth recently. Call Qatar 999 now, follow the call-taker's ambulance and emergency-transport instructions, and do not self-drive. Do not delay emergency care.
- Call Back If: worsening headache; vision changes worsen.

Prompt postpartum headache review

- Arrange prompt clinical assessment through the locally approved Qatar maternity pathway; the exact non-emergency destination remains GOVERNANCE_REQUIRED. Seek emergency help on 999 if the headache becomes severe or vision change, fainting, seizure, breathing difficulty, chest pain, severe upper abdominal pain, or marked swelling develops.
- Call Back If: headache becomes severe; vision changes or swelling develop.

First aid

- Call Qatar emergency services on 999 now. Do not drive yourself. Tell the call handler that the patient gave birth recently. Call Qatar 999 now, follow the call-taker's ambulance and emergency-transport instructions, and do not self-drive. Do not delay emergency care.

References

- NHS.UK, "Pre-eclampsia", <https://www.nhs.uk/conditions/pre-eclampsia/> (page last reviewed 23 March 2026) - explicitly covers postpartum onset
- CDC Hear Her, urgent maternal warning signs during pregnancy or within one year after pregnancy, <https://www.cdc.gov/hearher/>

Provenance

Shaped to mirror the licensed After-Hours Telehealth Triage Guidelines database structure. This is IST open-source guideline content derived from cited public sources; it is not licensed STCC content. Question.DispositionLevel=null marks a See More Appropriate Guideline redirect. Demographic variants contain only source-supported differences; identical thresholds are documented rather than fabricated. Local destinations and TelemedicineEligible values require IST clinical governance approval. UAT DATA ONLY - NOT FOR REAL-PATIENT CARE OR PRODUCTION USE.

Manifest hash: 140e1618e14286fbca74c60bdbf1cd7bad752514f4cead234b0b34a172b915b1 | Status: BLOCKED_BY_RESEARCH_GAP